

Tether

A relationship practice for two people who don't share a single story.

Version 1.0 Date 17 Sept 2026 Status Approved for build Primary market United States
Target iOS 17+ (iPhone), v0.1 in 90 days

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01 Executive summary

Tether is a private, two-person relationship app. It helps a couple build a small daily practice together — one prompt, one mood, one shared reflection — while respecting that the two people involved may not share the same faith, worldview, or cultural background.

Every major competitor (Paired, Lasting, Couply, Evergreen, Relish, Twogle) is either secular-generic or implicitly Christian. None of them let a Hindu–Muslim, Christian–atheist, or interfaith couple see themselves in the product. In the United States roughly four in ten marriages cross religious lines and about thirty percent of adults are religiously unaffiliated. **That is the market Tether serves, and it is currently unserved.**

Positioning statement

Tether is the relationship app for couples who don't share a single worldview. Each partner chooses their own wisdom track. The practice is shared; the beliefs are not.

02 Problem statement

Problem	Evidence	Tether's response
No app serves multi-faith couples	All major couples apps assume a shared worldview. Implicitly Christian or aggressively secular.	Per-partner wisdom tracks. Shared prompts built from the intersection of both tracks.
Partner sync failure	The predecessor product's most-reported failure was users trapped in an invite loop waiting for a partner who never appeared. 30–40% of invitees never install.	Six-screen pairing resilience suite: QR, link, and code paths; waiting room; nudges; 72-hour Solo Mode fallback.
Enthusiasm asymmetry	"Only works if both partners engage" is the most common criticism of every app in the category. One partner is nearly always the initiator.	Solo Mode as a first-class product path, not a consolation prize. Full value with zero partner involvement.
Habit drop-off	Daily couples apps lose users in week two. Multi-field journaling is experienced as homework.	A sixty-second loop: one prompt, one mood tap, one sentence. Streak freezes instead of guilt.
Generic content	Reviewers consistently call competitor content repetitive and generic.	Content engine with four layers: universal psychology, wisdom track, cultural context, language.

03 Goals and non-goals

Goals

- **G1** — Multi-worldview couples feel genuinely represented.
- **G2** — Pairing completion above 60%.
- **G3** — Day-30 retention above 25%.
- **G4** — Deliver full value when only one partner joins.
- **G5** — Be the safest, most private app in the category.
- **G6** — Reach \$10k MRR within 12 months of US launch.

Non-goals (explicitly out of scope)

- Not therapy, and not a replacement for it.
- Not a dating or matchmaking product.
- Not a social network in v1.
- Not a crisis or emergency service — we detect and refer.
- Not a co-parenting, household logistics, or finance tool.
- No advertising, ever. No selling of user content.

04 Target users and personas

P1 — Priya & Alex Primary

Interfaith couple, US, married 2 years. Priya is Hindu, Alex is lapsed Catholic. Both 29, urban, dual-income. They argue about holidays and about how to raise future children. Priya wants structure; Alex is sceptical of "apps for feelings." Neither has found a relationship product that reflects them.

- **Goal** — Build a shared practice without either person converting or compromising.
- **Frustration** — Every app either pushes Christian framing or strips all meaning out.
- **Tether wins when** — Each sees their own wisdom in the app, and shared prompts feel neutral but not empty.

P2 — Maya & Jordan Primary

Secular, therapy-literate, US, together 5 years. Both in individual therapy. They know Gottman and attachment theory. They want evidence-based tools, not inspirational quotes.

- **Goal** — Practical skill-building: conflict repair, emotional bids, repair attempts.
- **Frustration** — Finds competitor content shallow and repetitive.
- **Tether wins when** — Content is clearly grounded in Gottman, EFT, attachment, and NVC — and says so.

P3 — Fatima & Dan Secondary

Fatima is Muslim, Dan is agnostic. Navigating family expectations and in-law dynamics. Dan worries about being asked to believe something; Fatima worries about being asked to let go of something.

P4 — Solo Sarah Critical

Sarah wants to work on her relationship. Her partner has downloaded three couples apps and opened none of them. Every app she has tried has dead-ended at the invite screen.

- **Goal** — Start anyway, without waiting for permission or participation.
- **Frustration** — "Come back when your partner joins" is a dead end.
- **Tether wins when** — She gets real value on day one alone, and everything merges when he eventually joins.

P5 — Long-distance Later

Different time zones, asynchronous. Needs time-zone-aware prompt delivery and no "you missed yesterday" guilt.

05 Success metrics

Metric	Definition	Target	Why it matters
Pairing completion	Invites sent → active two-person pair	> 60%	The metric that killed the predecessor
D30 retention	% of installs active on day 30	> 25%	Category runs 10–20%
Weekly completion	Prompts answered per active partner per week	> 3	Proxy for habit formation
Trial → paid	14-day trial conversion	> 25%	Validates pricing and paywall
Solo → paired	Solo users who eventually pair	> 30%	Validates the whole Solo Mode bet
D7 onboarding completion	Users finishing the 7-day ritual	> 55%	Predicts long-term retention
Safety events handled	Crisis signals correctly escalated	100%	Non-negotiable, zero tolerance

06 Release scope

Release	Theme	Contents
v0.1 Days 1–90	Prove the loop	Onboarding · wisdom tracks (Secular, Biblical) · Love Languages · Solo Mode · pairing suite · daily loop · journal · mood · Pulse · AI coach v1 · safety · paywall · privacy
v1.0 Months 4–6	Prove the moat	Vedic and Quranic tracks · AI coach memory v2 · voice · cultural modules · weekly recap · streak freeze · Spanish
v1.5 Months 7–9	Expand	Interfaith Bridge module · Hindi · India pricing and UPI · therapist directory · widgets
v2.0 Months 10–12	Scale	Moderated community · additional languages · Android feature parity polish · web companion

Explicitly cut from v0.1

Community · localisation beyond English · India pricing · therapist directory · cultural modules beyond US · games and extra quizzes · watch app · widgets · web.

07 Functional requirements

Priority key: **Must** v0.1 blocker **Should** v1.0 **Could** later

7.1 Identity and onboarding

ID	Requirement	Pri	Acceptance criteria
FR-001	Account creation	Must	Sign in with Apple, Google, or email. No phone number required — competitors lose users here. Account created in under 20 seconds.
FR-002	Per-partner wisdom track	Must	Each partner independently selects a track: Secular/Psychology, Vedic/Dharmic, Quranic, Biblical. At v0.1 ship Secular + Biblical. Choice is per user, not per couple, and is editable in settings.
FR-003	Love Languages assessment	Must	Standard 5-language assessment, ~20 questions, under 2 minutes. Result shown immediately. Stored per user. Framed as a fun tool, never as science — see FR-041.
FR-004	7-day onboarding ritual	Must	Day 1 track · Day 2 Love Languages · Day 3 first prompt · Day 4 invite partner · Day 5 first shared entry · Day 6 Pulse baseline · Day 7 AI coach intro. Each step skippable.
FR-005	Notification permission	Must	Requested after first value moment (day 3), not at launch. Pre-permission explainer screen shown first.

7.2 Pairing — the critical path

ID	Requirement	Pri	Acceptance criteria
FR-010	Three invite paths	Must	Every invite offers: shareable deep link, QR code, and 6-digit code. All three land the partner in the app on the correct screen, authed or not.
FR-011	Waiting room	Must	Never a dead spinner. Shows invite status, time sent, and a copyable pre-written message to send. Manual "check again" control.
FR-012	Nudge sequence	Must	At 24h and 72h, one-tap re-invite via iMessage, WhatsApp, or SMS. Max 3 nudges, then stop.
FR-013	In-person QR pairing	Must	Scanning a partner's QR while both are present pairs instantly, no network round-trip dependency. Eliminates the entire class of remote link failures.
FR-014	72-hour Solo Mode fallback	Must	If no pairing after 72h, proactively offer: "Start solo. Everything syncs the moment they join." One tap. This is the single most important screen in the product.
FR-015	Pairing confirmation	Must	Both partners receive a push. A celebration moment, not a toast. Marks the start of the shared streak.
FR-016	Solo → paired merge	Must	All pre-pairing content is preserved and unlocked together in a merge ceremony. Nothing is lost, nothing is retroactively hidden.
FR-017	Unpair	Should	Either partner can unpair. Requires confirmation. Content is retained per user, not deleted.

7.3 The daily loop

ID	Requirement	Pri	Acceptance criteria
FR-020	One daily prompt	Must	Exactly one prompt per day per couple. Not four. Derived from the intersection of both partners' tracks.
FR-021	Mood tap	Must	Single 1–5 selection. One tap. No text required.
FR-022	One-sentence reply	Must	Single-line input, 280 characters. Voice-to-text enabled and encouraged.
FR-023	Hidden until both reply	Must	A reply is invisible to the other partner until both have answered. Drives reciprocity and removes performance pressure.
FR-024	Streak with freeze	Must	Counts consecutive days both replied. Two automatic freeze days per month. Never punitive language.
FR-025	Smart send time	Should	Learns each partner's active hours and sends individually. Never both partners at the same timestamp.
FR-026	Solo mode loop	Must	Full loop works for one user: prompts, mood, journal, Pulse, AI coach. No partner-gated surfaces.

7.4 Journal, Pulse, and insight

ID	Requirement	Pri	Acceptance criteria
FR-030	Couple journal	Must	Mood + one line. Optional private-to-me toggle on any entry. Chronological, searchable, exportable.
FR-031	Relationship Pulse	Must	Three states: Thriving, Drifting, Strained. Computed from mood, reply cadence, and sentiment. Tap through shows why.
FR-032	Weekly recap	Should	Sunday summary: streak, Pulse trend, a highlighted memory, one suggested focus. Push + in-app.
FR-033	Trend awareness	Should	Surfaces sustained change: "You've been drifting for two weeks." Gentle, never alarmist.

7.5 AI coach

ID	Requirement	Pri	Acceptance criteria
FR-040	Conversational coach	Must	Free-text and voice input. Responds with grounded, non-generic guidance. Latency under 3s to first token.
FR-041	Evidence grounding	Must	Core guidance draws on Gottman Method, EFT, attachment theory, NVC. Love Languages is used for engagement only — the model has limited empirical support and must never be presented as clinical.
FR-042	Per-partner wisdom grounding	Must	Responses reflect the asking partner's own track, not a generic blend.
FR-043	Couple memory	Should	Retrieves relevant past entries and prior conversations. Can reference a conflict from three weeks ago. Session context persists.
FR-044	Voice mode	Should	Full voice input and spoken response. Nobody types during a real disagreement.
FR-045	De-escalation mode	Could	When both partners log high-distress mood within a short window, proactively offer a cool-down protocol.
FR-046	Scope refusal	Must	Refuses diagnosis, medication advice, legal advice, and divorce recommendation. Redirects to human professionals.

7.6 Safety, privacy, and trust

ID	Requirement	Pri	Acceptance criteria
FR-050	Safety classifier	Must	All AI input and all journal text passes a crisis classifier before storage or response. Detects self-harm, suicidality, abuse, and violence.
FR-051	Crisis escalation	Must	On detection: suppress all couple-facing output, show a partner-only resource card with US hotlines (988, National Domestic Violence Hotline). Never surface one partner's crisis signal to the other.
FR-052	Pause state	Should	User can pause all prompts and notifications for 1–30 days without losing streak or data.
FR-053	End-to-end encryption	Must	Journal entries and AI conversations encrypted client-side. Server stores ciphertext only and cannot read content.
FR-054	Data export and delete	Must	One-tap full export (JSON + human-readable). One-tap full account deletion, hard delete within 30 days.
FR-055	No content analytics	Must	Behavioural analytics only. Journal and chat content is never sent to any analytics provider. Stated publicly.
FR-056	Scope disclaimer	Must	Shown at onboarding, in ToS, and persistently near the AI coach: Tether is not therapy and not a crisis service.

7.7 Monetisation

ID	Requirement	Pri	Acceptance criteria
FR-060	One subscription covers both	Must	Industry standard. Either partner purchasing unlocks premium for both. Stated on the paywall, pricing screen, and App Store subtitle.
FR-061	Free tier	Must	Free forever: Solo Mode, 1 prompt/week, mood tracking, first-track content, Love Languages, 5 AI messages/month.
FR-062	14-day trial	Must	Full premium, no ads, covers both partners. Longer than the category-standard 7 days.
FR-063	Pricing	Must	US \$12.99/mo, \$79.99/yr, \$149.99/yr Couples+. India ₹149/mo, ₹899/yr, ₹1,799/yr Couples+. PPP tiers handled by store.
FR-064	Paywall placement	Must	After first value moment, never before. Privacy promise is a paywall bullet.
FR-065	Cancellation	Must	Self-serve in-app and on web in under 3 taps. No retention dark patterns — competitor cancellation friction is a widely cited complaint we will not replicate.

08 User flows

8.1 Onboarding

- 1 **Welcome** — name, and the promise: two people, one practice.
- 2 **Wisdom track** — four options, each partner chooses their own. "You can change this later."
- 3 **Love Languages** — 20 questions, under 2 minutes, immediate result.
- 4 **First prompt** — answered solo. Delivers value before asking for anything.
- 5 **Notification permission** — with pre-explainer, after value is proven.
- 6 **Invite partner** — three paths offered simultaneously.
- 7 **Waiting room or continue solo** — never a dead end.

8.2 Pairing

- 1 **Invite screen** — link, QR, and code all visible at once.
- 2 **Waiting room** — live status, copyable message, manual refresh.
- 3 **24h** — gentle nudge option.
- 4 **72h** — proactive Solo Mode offer: "Start now. Everything syncs when they join."
- 5 **Partner joins** — merge ceremony, both notified, shared streak begins.

8.3 Daily loop

- 1 **Push** — personalised send time, per partner.
- 2 **Open** — one prompt, immediately visible. No navigation required.
- 3 **Mood tap** — one tap.
- 4 **Reply** — one sentence, voice or text.
- 5 **Lock** — hidden until partner replies.
- 6 **Unlock** — both see both. Optional reaction.
- 7 **Streak** — updated, with freeze days available.

8.4 Safety escalation

- 1 **Input** — user writes in journal or AI chat.
- 2 **Classify** — on-device pre-screen, then server classifier before storage.
- 3 **Trigger** — crisis signal detected.
- 4 **Suppress** — no couple-facing output. Partner sees nothing.
- 5 **Support** — resource card, only to the user who wrote it.
- 6 **Log** — safety event recorded for review, content not stored in plaintext.

09 User stories and acceptance criteria

Epic A — I can see myself in this product

- As an interfaith partner, I want to choose my own wisdom track so that I'm not force-fed someone else's beliefs. **Accept:** track selected independently, reflected in all my content, changeable in settings.
- As a secular user, I want evidence-based content so I trust the guidance. **Accept:** methodology cited, no faith framing on the Secular track.

Epic B — I can start, even alone

- As the more enthusiastic partner, I want to begin without waiting so the app isn't useless to me. **Accept:** Solo Mode fully functional on day one; no partner-gated surfaces.
- As a solo user whose partner later joins, I want my history preserved. **Accept:** merge ceremony, zero data loss.

Epic C — We can actually pair

- As an inviter, I want multiple ways to invite so a broken link doesn't kill it. **Accept:** link, QR, and code all functional; in-person QR always works.
- As someone whose partner hasn't responded, I want to know what to do. **Accept:** waiting room shows status and offers a copyable message; 72h solo fallback.

Epic D — The habit sticks

- As a busy partner, I want the daily action to be tiny. **Accept:** prompt + mood + one sentence completable in under 60 seconds.
- As someone who missed a day, I want grace not guilt. **Accept:** two freeze days per month, no punitive copy.

Epic E — I am safe here

- As a user in crisis, I want appropriate help. **Accept:** hotlines surfaced immediately, partner never notified.
- As a privacy-conscious user, I want my words unreadable to the company. **Accept:** E2E encryption on journal and chat; clearly stated.
- As a paying user, I want to cancel easily. **Accept:** under 3 taps, in-app or web, no dark patterns.

10 Content requirements

Content architecture — the real moat

Layer 1 Universal psychological core (Gottman, EFT, attachment, NVC) → **Layer 2** Wisdom track expression (Secular, Vedic, Quranic, Biblical) → **Layer 3** Cultural context (US individualist, US immigrant, India joint-family, Global) → **Layer 4** Language.

One core, many expressions. This is how you scale to eight languages without eight times the writing.

- **Volume at v0.1** — 90 days of daily prompts, minimum. Two tracks live (Secular, Biblical). US cultural context only.
- **Quality bar** — benchmark against the Gottman Card Decks, which offer 1,000+ research-backed prompts for free. Any prompt that reads like a horoscope gets cut.
- **Review gate** — every faith-track prompt reviewed by a practitioner of that tradition. Non-negotiable for credibility.
- **Tone** — warm, plain, non-clinical. Never cheerful when the content is serious. No exclamation marks in sensitive contexts.
- **Never** — diagnose, prescribe, shame, or assume the relationship should continue.

11 Non-functional requirements

Area	Requirement
Performance	Cold start under 2s. Prompt screen interactive under 1s. AI first token under 3s. All reads served locally.
Offline	Full read and write offline. Sync queues and resolves automatically. Zero data loss on conflict.
Reliability	99.5% uptime. No single point of failure for reading existing content.
Accessibility	WCAG 2.1 AA. Dynamic Type to 200%. Full VoiceOver. Contrast 4.5:1 minimum. Reduced-motion honoured.
Security	TLS 1.3 in transit. AES-256-GCM client-side for journal and chat. Keys in device keychain, never server-side.
Privacy	No third-party SDK access to content. No IDFA. Data residency documented. CCPA and GDPR compliant.
Platform	iOS 17+ (iPhone), native SwiftUI. Android is deferred by the current build decision — accepted trade-off, tracked as a known gap against roughly half the US market.
Localisation	English at v0.1. Spanish v1.0. Hindi v1.5. RTL architecture ready from day one (needed for Urdu and Arabic later).

12 Risks, dependencies, open questions

Risk	Severity	Mitigation
Partner never joins	High	Solo Mode and pairing suite are both in v0.1. This is the primary bet.
AI produces harmful output	High	Safety classifier, scope refusal, human escalation, disclaimers. Liability insurance.
Content feels generic	Med	Per-partner wisdom grounding and couple memory. Hard for competitors to copy quickly.
Competitor copies multi-faith	Med	Content depth and reviewed faith content are slow to build. Move fast on the wedge.
US liability exposure	Med	LLC formation, clear disclaimers, E&O insurance, documented scope.
AI inference cost scales	Low	Response caching, tiered models, monthly usage caps per tier.

Open questions

- Free tier AI message cap — 5/month, or unlimited with a weaker model?
- Should Relationship Pulse ever predict, or only describe? Recommendation: describe only, in v1.
- Anonymous mode — can a user try Tether without an account? Recommendation: yes, deferred to v1.0.
- Faith-track reviewer compensation model — volunteer advisory board or paid?

13 Launch criteria

Definition of done for v0.1

- All **Must** requirements shipped and tested.
- 90 days of prompts live for both launch tracks, faith-reviewed.
- Safety classifier tested against a red-team set with zero misses.
- E2E encryption independently verified — server cannot read content.
- Pairing funnel instrumented end to end.
- 50 real couples through TestFlight, minimum 2 weeks.
- App Store review requirements met, including account deletion.
- Legal: ToS, privacy policy, disclaimers, LLC formed.